

U.S. Foreign Policy

Crash Course Government & Politics | Episode #50

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1. What is Foreign Policy?

Foreign policy is the collection of policies that determine America's relations with other nations and foreign entities. It is considered a **public good** — everyone benefits from a safer world, but no individual can achieve it alone.

Five core areas:

Area	Description
Diplomacy	Relations and negotiations with foreign governments
Military / Security	Defense, deterrence, counter-terrorism
Human Rights	International treaties and peacekeeping
Economic Policy	Trade, tariffs, energy access
Environmental Policy	Global environmental initiatives

2. The Three Goals of Foreign Policy

■ Goal 1 — Security (Top Priority)

Originally meant repelling invaders. Today it encompasses physical defense, transportation, energy, cyber-security, food security, and counter-terrorism. Military force is considered a **last resort** — costly in lives and money, and public support drops the longer a conflict lasts.

Era	Strategy
Washington era	Isolationism — avoid 'foreign entanglements'
WWI / WWII	International involvement; threats to world order = U.S. threat
Cold War	Deterrence — build military strength to discourage Soviet attack
Post-9/11	Global War on Terror + doctrine of preemptive war

■ Goal 2 — Economics (Second Priority)

Key objectives: expand U.S. opportunities, attract foreign investment, secure energy access, and keep consumer prices low.

- Membership in the **WTO** (World Trade Organization)
- 'Most Favored Nation' status for low-tariff trading partners
- Regional trade agreements such as **NAFTA**

■ Goal 3 — Making the World Better (Third Priority)

- **Human Rights:** Party to many international treaties; has *not* joined the International Criminal Court due to sovereignty concerns.
- **Peacekeeping:** Prefers own coalitions or **NATO** over UN peacekeeping missions.
- **Environment:** Lags behind other nations; when growth conflicts with environmental protection, the U.S. tends to choose economic growth.

3. Who Makes Foreign Policy?

Foreign policy is considered the **least democratic** type of government policy, intentionally concentrated in fewer hands to maintain **predictability** — especially critical in sensitive negotiations involving nuclear arms.

Actor	Role & Powers
President	Chief diplomat; negotiates treaties; final decision-maker on all foreign policy
State Dept.	Handles day-to-day diplomatic work with foreign governments
CIA / NSA / DHS	Intelligence gathering to inform negotiations and policy
Congress (Senate)	Ratifies treaties (requires 2/3 vote); controls defense spending via power of the purse
Interest Groups	Shape the policy agenda; limited direct influence on actual decisions

Key notes on Congress:

- Treaties need a **2/3 Senate vote** → Presidents often use *executive agreements* instead (simple majority in both houses).
- Congressional committees provide expertise but less than full-time bureaucracies.
- Congress can hold hearings (e.g., Benghazi) but rarely changes normal operations.

4. Priority Summary

Priority	Area	Key Mechanism
1st	Security	Military, deterrence, preemptive war, counter-terrorism
2nd	Economics	WTO, NAFTA, trade agreements, energy policy
3rd	Human Rights & Environment	Treaties, peacekeeping, environmental initiatives